The superannuating officers are a high-risk, instant return target. They approach such officers only after ascertaining their level of integrity, and the quantum of barter to break it. Those fishing know what an upright Indian bureaucrat or intelligence officer must have earned at the end of his service. Some of them find the promise of a slightly wealthy retired life tantalizing after a middle-class sojourn of more than three decades.

M K Dhar was to retire by the beginning of 1995, a few months after Mariam Rasheeda was arrested. It is also on record that Dhar had made some desperate attempts to get his official date of birth 'corrected' so that he could get an extension of service. When a senior officer nearing retirement is handling a sensitive case, it is usual for the government to give him an extension beyond superannuation to complete the assignment. Dhar had tried in vain to weave a story of a Pakistan conspiracy by arresting a Muslim religious leader in a northern state, but when the government was convinced of the leader's background and standing, Dhar had to eat a humble pie. It is at this juncture he saw the potential of the ISRO spy case.

In *Open Secrets*, written after the CBI indicted the IB and the Kerala Police for virtually foisting the ISRO spy case, Dhar paints himself as an Abhimanyu of sorts. After the castle of a case he built fell like nine pins, Dhar blamed virtually everyone, including then IB director D C Pathak, then CBI director Vijaya Rama Rao, and then Prime Minister P V Narasimha Rao. In the process of explaining his strategy, Dhar inadvertently makes some confessions including one that admits that the IB had interrogated the ISRO spy case accused and denied Kerala Police access to IB's tech team, which he had instructed to videograph the entire interrogation process. 'Altogether seventy-one black and white and one colour video cassettes were produced by the TechInt boys,' boasts Dhar.

Why did the IB not produce these recordings to prove that there was no torture of the accused as the CBI found? Well, Dhar blames it on his boss for not having a separate counsel for the IB, which had to move the court along with the CBI. At one place, he confesses: 'We were in no position to substantiate most of the linkages revealed during interrogation.'